

FREE BUYER'S GUIDE FOR UK CARE PROVIDERS

How to choose a website agency for your care service

The questions worth asking any agency, freelancer or platform before you sign, whoever you choose. With a one page scorecard to compare them side by side.

INSIDE

- CQC rating display and Regulation 20A
- Accessibility for older visitors
- Enquiries, fees and availability
- Local search, schema and recruitment pages
- GDPR, ownership, hosting and life after launch
- Red flags and a side by side scorecard

START HERE

How to use this guide

Choosing who builds your website is a decision you live with for years. This guide lists the questions worth asking any website agency, freelancer or platform before you sign, whoever you choose, including us.

Each section explains why the topic matters for a care service, what to ask, what a good answer sounds like and, where there is one, a free way to check a website yourself. At the end there is a list of red flags and a one page scorecard to compare up to three agencies side by side.

It applies to care homes, nursing homes, home care agencies, supported living and other care services. Where it says "care home", read your own service.

CONTENTS

1. Your CQC rating (Regulation 20A)	3
2. Accessibility for older visitors	3
3. Enquiry handling and response	4
4. Fees and availability	4
5. Local search for "care homes in [town]"	5
6. Care-specific schema	5
7. Carer recruitment pages	6
8. GDPR and care data	6
9. Who owns the domain, hosting and logins	7
10. What happens after launch	7
Red flags to watch for	8
When another option is the right one	8
Scorecard: compare agencies side by side	9
About TRG Digital	10

1 Your CQC rating (Regulation 20A)

WHY IT MATTERS

Regulation 20A requires your current CQC rating to be shown clearly on your website. The official CQC widget keeps it up to date automatically, but someone has to add it, in the right places, and check it after each inspection.

It is simple to do and easy to miss if nobody on the project has run a care service.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ How will our CQC rating be shown, and on which pages?
- ☐ Will you use the official CQC widget, so the rating updates itself?
- ☐ Who checks the rating is still correct after each inspection?
- ☐ Where will our registered manager and provider details appear?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

The official widget, added to every page that matters, with a named person who checks it after each inspection. The agency raises Regulation 20A before you do.

Check it yourself, free: [CQC Rating Display Checker](http://www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/cqc-rating-display-checker), www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/cqc-rating-display-checker

2 Accessibility for older visitors

WHY IT MATTERS

Many of the people reading a care website are in their seventies or eighties, or are adult children reading on a phone late at night. Stylish templates often use light grey text, small type and thin fonts that look lovely in a preview and are hard work for the people you most need to reach.

Under the Equality Act 2010, anyone providing a service to the public must make reasonable adjustments for disabled people (section 20) and must not discriminate in the way the service is provided (section 29). Your website is one of the ways you provide your service. Building to WCAG 2.2 AA is the clearest way to show you have taken this seriously.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ Will the site be built to WCAG 2.2 AA, and how will you test it?
- ☐ Can visitors enlarge the text, switch to high contrast, or have a page read aloud?
- ☐ Will text meet AA contrast, and still read on a phone in daylight?
- ☐ Will anything slide, fade or auto-play while someone is trying to read?
- ☐ Will the content system ask for alt text on every image your team adds?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

Testing with the keyboard, screen readers and contrast checks, on phones, tablets and computers. Large, dark text, simple menus, big buttons, and no carousels.

Check it yourself, free: [Care Website Accessibility Check](http://www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-website-accessibility-check),
www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-website-accessibility-check

3 Enquiry handling and response

WHY IT MATTERS

A family looking for care is often under pressure, worried about money and reading on a phone. They want a person to call. A form that expires halfway through, asks for a puzzle to prove they are human, or lands in an inbox nobody watches loses them.

Replying to enquiries quickly matters as much as the website itself.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ Who receives each enquiry, and how quickly will we know about it?
- ☐ Will there be a phone number and one obvious action on every page, in the same place?
- ☐ Will the form work on a phone, with no puzzle and no session that expires mid enquiry?
- ☐ Will each enquiry show which page and which source it came from?
- ☐ What will you report each month: enquiries, or just visits?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

Enquiries go straight to named people, with the page they came from. Reporting is about enquiries, not traffic.

Check it yourself, free: [Care Website Grader \(scores your enquiry journey\)](http://www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/website-grader),
www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/website-grader

4 Fees and availability

WHY IT MATTERS

Families want fees, funding, the CQC rating, photos of real rooms and a person to call. Fees information families can find, and a plain funding explainer, are two of the care details most often left out of a general website brief.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ Where will our fees, or how our fees are worked out, appear on the site?
- ☐ Will there be a plain English guide to funding for families?
- ☐ Can we show current availability, and can our own team update it?

- ☐ Will care terms such as domiciliary, respite, CHC and FNC be explained?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

The agency asks how you want to present fees, rather than leaving them out by default, and your team can keep availability current without calling anyone.

Check it yourself, free: [Care Website Grader \(checks fees and funding\)](http://www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/website-grader),
www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/website-grader

5 Local search for "care homes in [town]"

WHY IT MATTERS

Care searches in most towns are crowded with directories and large groups. Winning "care homes in [town]" takes local service pages, a strong Google Business Profile and content that answers family questions.

Website platforms handle the technical basics of search well. Deciding which towns, services and questions deserve their own pages, writing them and keeping them improving is the work, and it is rarely in a build quote.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ Which towns and services will get their own pages?
- ☐ If we are moving from an old site, how will you protect our current Google rankings?
- ☐ Will our name, address and phone number match on the site, Google and directories?
- ☐ Is local search work part of the build, or a separate ongoing service?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

A clear list of the local pages you will get, a plan for keeping the pages Google already knows about working, and honesty about what is ongoing work.

Check it yourself, free: [Local Competitor Snapshot](http://www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-competitor-snapshot), www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-competitor-snapshot

6 Care-specific schema

WHY IT MATTERS

Search engines understand a site better with structured data that describes the service, the location and common questions. Most platforms add general markup. Care service and FAQ markup usually needs custom code, and your CQC rating should be added in the correct, compliant way.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ What structured data will each page carry: care service, location, FAQs?
- ☐ How will our CQC rating be represented in it?
- ☐ Will each vacancy carry job markup, so it can appear in Google for Jobs?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

A specific answer naming the markup, not "the plugin handles SEO".

Check it yourself, free: [Care Schema Generator](http://www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-schema-generator), www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-schema-generator

7 Carer recruitment pages

WHY IT MATTERS

Most providers need a steady flow of carers as much as they need residents or clients. Carers look for work on their phones, usually between shifts. A careers page that hides the pay, sends people to a separate jobs site, or asks for a CV they do not have loses them in seconds. A single jobs page rarely ranks.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ Will every vacancy have its own page, with the pay shown up front?
- ☐ Will vacancies be marked up for Google for Jobs?
- ☐ Can someone apply on a phone, with a CV or without one?
- ☐ Can our team add and close vacancies themselves?
- ☐ Will there be careers pages for the towns we recruit in?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

Job pages on your own website that your team runs, a quick mobile application, and pay shown on every role.

Check it yourself, free: [Care Job Advert Checker](http://www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-job-advert-checker), www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-job-advert-checker

8 GDPR and care data

WHY IT MATTERS

A family enquiry often includes health details about a relative, which is special category data under UK GDPR. The form itself is easy. Deciding what to ask, who receives it, where it is stored and what your privacy notice says takes care knowledge, not a template. Knowing exactly where family data goes also makes UK GDPR simpler.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ What will our forms ask, and what will they deliberately not ask?
- ☐ Where are enquiries and CVs stored, who can open them, and for how long?
- ☐ Is personal data encrypted in transit and at rest?
- ☐ Will our privacy notice cover everything the forms collect?
- ☐ Are you registered with the ICO, and who keeps the software patched?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

Forms that collect only what is needed, CVs kept in a private, encrypted area and deleted after a period you choose, and a privacy notice written to match.

9

Who owns the domain, hosting and logins

WHY IT MATTERS

If an agency or freelancer registered your domain, set up the hosting and holds the admin login, you depend on them staying in business and in touch. If everything is in your name, another developer can pick the site up. If it is not, getting it back can be slow. Check this now rather than when something breaks.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ Will the domain be registered in our organisation's name?
- ☐ Whose account will the hosting be in?
- ☐ Will we have our own admin login from day one?
- ☐ Who owns the words, photos and design?
- ☐ What happens, and what does it cost, if we leave?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

The domain, the hosting account and every login in your organisation's name, with clear, written exit terms.

10

What happens after launch

WHY IT MATTERS

The problems on inherited care websites are rarely about the platform. They are about what happens after launch. When the build is paid for and the maintenance is not, updates stop, and an outdated site that collects family enquiries is a data protection worry as well as a technical one.

To compare quotes fairly, add hosting, maintenance, new pages and any search work to the build price, then compare the cost per enquiry over two or three years rather than the price on day one.

ASK ANY AGENCY

- ☐ Who updates the platform, theme and plugins, and how often?
- ☐ What exactly does your maintenance agreement cover?
- ☐ What will new pages cost after launch?
- ☐ Who covers if our contact is ill or on holiday?
- ☐ Who will we actually speak to week to week, and how often do we review results?

A GOOD ANSWER SOUNDS LIKE

A written maintenance agreement, a named contact with cover, and regular reviews of enquiries.

Check it yourself, free: [Enquiry Value Calculator \(what one enquiry is worth\)](https://www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/enquiry-value-calculator),
www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/enquiry-value-calculator

BEFORE YOU SIGN

Red flags to watch for

None of these on its own means an agency is bad. Two or three together are worth a careful conversation before you commit.

- ! They cannot show you care websites they have built, or how those sites perform.
- ! The domain, hosting or admin login will be in their name, not yours.
- ! Nobody mentions the CQC rating or Regulation 20A until you do.
- ! The design leans on light grey text, small type, sliders or auto-playing video.
- ! The quote covers the build but says nothing about updates, security or maintenance.
- ! Monthly reports count visits but never enquiries.
- ! A new site is planned with no plan for the pages Google already knows about.
- ! Enquiry forms ask for health details with no privacy notice to match.
- ! One person holds every login and there is no cover when they are away.
- ! Vague answers about what happens, and what it costs, if you leave.

BEING FAIR: WHEN ANOTHER OPTION IS THE RIGHT ONE

A care specialist is not the right answer for everyone. These are the situations where another route often makes more sense.

A DIY builder such as Wix or Squarespace

A sensible start for a new service that needs something presentable this month, or when the budget is small. Add the CQC widget, a clear phone number and a simple enquiry form.

A WordPress freelancer

Excellent value if they have built care websites, answer the phone and offer a proper maintenance agreement.

A general web agency

A good fit if they have built care sites before and can show how they perform, or if care is one part of a wider group.

Directory listings

The fastest way to be found and a strong source of reviews. Best alongside a website you own, not instead of one.

ONE PAGE SCORECARD

Compare agencies side by side

Score each agency 0 (no or unclear), 1 (partly) or 2 (yes, clearly) on every line, using their answers to the questions in this guide. Print this page for each round of calls.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR	Agency A	Agency B	Agency C
Name			
CQC rating shown with the official widget, and checked after each inspection	☐	☐	☐
Built to WCAG 2.2 AA and tested for older visitors	☐	☐	☐
Enquiries reach named people quickly, with a phone number on every page	☐	☐	☐
Fees, funding and availability easy for families to find	☐	☐	☐
Local pages for our towns and services, with current rankings protected	☐	☐	☐
Care service, FAQ and job markup included	☐	☐	☐
Careers pages with pay shown and a quick mobile application	☐	☐	☐
Care data handled carefully: lean forms, secure storage, matching privacy notice	☐	☐	☐
Domain, hosting and every login in our name	☐	☐	☐
Clear maintenance, updates and security after launch	☐	☐	☐
Monthly reporting on enquiries, not just visits	☐	☐	☐
Has built care websites and can show how they perform	☐	☐	☐
Clear, fair terms if we leave	☐	☐	☐
TOTAL (out of 26)	☐	☐	☐

A high total is a good sign, but read the answers too. A lower scoring agency that is honest about what it does not do can be a safer choice than one that says yes to everything.

ABOUT THE AUTHORS

Ask us the same questions

TRG Digital builds websites and SEO for UK care providers, and nothing else. Our founder has more than 20 years in digital and years working inside care, which shapes how we build. It is fair to judge us on the work rather than the claim, so please put every question in this guide to us too, and hold us to the answers.

If a DIY builder, a freelancer or your current agency is the better fit for you right now, we would rather tell you so. We only work in care, and that is the point.

FREE TOOLS TO CHECK ANY WEBSITE, INCLUDING OURS

- **CQC Rating Display Checker** www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/cqc-rating-display-checker
- **Care Website Accessibility Check** www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-website-accessibility-check
- **Your Care Website Grader** www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/website-grader
- **Local Competitor Snapshot** www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-competitor-snapshot
- **Care Schema Generator** www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-schema-generator
- **Care Job Advert Checker** www.trgdigital.co.uk/tools/care-job-advert-checker

Ready to talk about a new website?

Tell us about your service and we will come back with ideas for your new website. A reply from a person within one working day.

www.trgdigital.co.uk/start-building-your-new-website

Or call 020 8064 1596